Sun has hydrogen gas and one quarter has helium gas. It is over a million times as big as the Earth. Hydrogen atoms combine or fuse together to form helium under enormous pressure. This process, called nuclear fusion releases enormous amount of energy as light and heat. It is this energy which makes Sun shine and provide heat. Sun is situated at the centre of the solar system. The strong gravitational fields cause other solar matter, mainly planets, asteroids, comets, meteoroids and other debris, to orbit around it. Sun is believed to be more than 4.6 billion years old.

Formation of the Sun

At the time of the Big Bang, hydrogen gas condensed to form huge clouds, which later concentrated and formed the numerous galaxies. Some of the hydrogen gas was left free and started floating around in our galaxy. With time, due to some changes, this free-floating hydrogen gas concentrated and paved way for the formation of the Sun and solar system. Gradually, the Sun and the solar system turned into a slowly spinning molecular cloud, composed of hydrogen and helium along with dust. The cloud started to undergo the process of compression, as a result of its own gravity. Its excessive and high-speed spinning ultimately resulted in its flattening into a giant disc.

9.2.2 Planets

A planet revolves around the Sun along a definite curved path which is called an orbit. It is elliptical. The time taken by a planet to complete one revolution is called its period of revolution.

Besides revolving around the Sun, a planet also rotates on its own axis like a top. The time taken by a planet to complete one rotation is called its period of rotation. The period of rotation of the Earth is 23 hours and 56 minutes and so the length of a day on Earth is taken as 24 hours. Table 9.1 tells about the length of a day on each planet.

The planets are spaced unevenly. The first four planets are relatively close together and close to the Sun. They form the inner solar system. Farther from the Sun is the outer solar system, where the planets are much more spread out. Thus the distance between Saturn and Uranus is much greater (about 20 times) than the distance between the Earth and the Mars.

Table 9.1 Length of a day on each planet

Planets	Length of a day
Mercury	58.65 days
Venus	243 days
Earth	23.93 hours
Mars	24.62 hours
Jupiter	9.92 hours
Saturn	10.23 hours
Uranus	17 hours
Neptune	18 hours

The four planets grouped together in the inner solar system are Mercury, Venus, Earth and Mars. They are called inner planets. They have a surface of solid rock crust and so are called terrestrial or rocky planets. Their insides, surfaces and atmospheres are formed in a similar way and form similar pattern. Our planet, Earth can be taken as a model of the other three planets.

The four large planets Jupiter, Saturn, Uranus and Neptune spread out in the outer solar system and slowly orbit the Sun are called outer planets. They are made of hydrogen, helium and other gases in huge amounts and have very dense atmosphere. They are known as gas giants and are called gaseous planets. The four outer planets Jupiter, Saturn, Uranus and Neptune have rings whereas the four inner planets do not have any rings. The rings are actually tiny pieces of rock covered with ice. Now let us learn about each planet in the solar system.

Mercury: Mercury is a rocky planet nearest to the Sun. It is very hot during day but very cold at night. Mercury can be easily observed thorough telescope than naked eye since it is very faint and small. It always appears in the eastern horizon or western horizon of the sky.

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